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Inferences

10 questions · ~15 min

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Q1

INFORMATION AND IDEAS

Microbes that live in shallow lakes and ponds produce methane, a harmful greenhouse gas. Ecologist Ralf Aben and his team wanted to see how different types of shallow-water plants might affect the amount of methane that escapes into the atmosphere. Aben's team set up some water tanks with soil and microbes from local ponds. Some tanks had a type of underwater plant that grows in the soil called watermilfoil. Other tanks had either duckweed, a type of plant that floats on the water's surface, or algae. Aben and his team found that tanks with duckweed and algae released higher levels of methane than tanks with watermilfoil did. This finding suggests that _____ blank

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. the presence of some kinds of underwater plants like watermilfoil helps prevent methane from escaping shallow lakes and ponds.
- B. shallow lakes and ponds release more methane than deeper bodies of water because shallow bodies of water usually have more plants than deep bodies of water do.
- C. shallow lakes and ponds are more likely to contain algae than to contain either watermilfoil or duckweed.
- D. having a mix of algae, underwater plants, and floating plants is the best way to reduce the amount of methane in shallow lakes and ponds.

To create the poems in her 2017 collection *One Last Word*, poet Nikki Grimes used a writing method called the golden shovel. This method often involves choosing a line from an existing poem and then using each word from that line as the last word of each line in a new poem. Grimes wanted the poems in *One Last Word* to honor important Black poets of the past, so she chose lines by poets such as Langston Hughes and Georgia Douglas Johnson. Writing in this way can be challenging and might seem as though it would produce awkward poems. However, reviewers praised *One Last Word* as a beautiful and powerful tribute to the poets who inspired it. This reaction suggests that _____ blank

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. most reviewers didn't understand Grimes's goal for *One Last Word*.
- B. Grimes successfully used the golden shovel method to achieve her goal for *One Last Word*.
- C. Langston Hughes and Georgia Douglas Johnson are two of Grimes's favorite poets.
- D. Grimes inspired many other writers to create poems using the golden shovel method.

Arthur Conan Doyle's stories about detective Sherlock Holmes were published between 1887 and 1927. They have inspired countless successful adaptations, including comic strips, movies, and a television series *Sherlock Hound*, directed by Hayao Miyazaki, who is celebrated for his animated movies. Until 2014, these stories were copyrighted. The right to adapt was only available to those who could afford the copyright fee and gain approval from the strict copyright holders of Doyle's estate. Some journalists predict that the number of Sherlock Holmes adaptations is likely to increase since the end of copyright means that _____ blank

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. Doyle's original stories will become hard to find.
- B. people will become more interested in detective stories than they were in the 1800s.
- C. producing adaptations will become easier and less expensive.
- D. the former copyright holders of Doyle's estate will return fees they collected.

In many cultures, a handshake can create trust between people. Engineer João Avelino and his team are designing a robot to shake hands with a human in order to improve human-robot interactions. The robot hand adjusts its movements and pressure to better imitate the feel of a human hand. The researchers want the robot's handshake to feel realistic because _____ blank

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. lifelike handshakes may make people more comfortable interacting with robots.
- B. it's easier to program a robot to perform handshakes than it is to program a robot to perform some other types of greetings.
- C. people are less likely to interact with robots that don't look like humans.
- D. the robot in the researchers' study may have uses other than interacting with humans.

In the 1950s and '60s, plant breeders created shorter varieties of wheat and rice plants with improved yields. Kelly Gillespie, Rex Bernardo, and other plant specialists are building on that work by exploring the development of shorter corn varieties. Greater height can allow individual plants to produce more ears of corn. However, greater height also makes the stalks more likely to snap or be uprooted in strong winds before the corn can be harvested. Because of this trade-off, some plant specialists suggest that shorter corn varieties will actually _____ blank

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. help improve yields of harvested corn by being more likely to survive in severe winds.
- B. be more likely to be uprooted due to the weight of the corn on the stalks.
- C. require more land for planting than short varieties of wheat and rice typically do.
- D. begin developing more ears of corn on each plant than the tallest variety of corn currently does.

In their book *Smart Pricing*, Jagmohan Raju and Z. John Zhang consider musicians' use of the nontraditional "pay as you wish" pricing model. This model generally offers listeners the choice to pay more or less than a suggested price for a song or album—or even to pay nothing at all. As the authors note, that's the option most listeners chose for an album by the band Harvey Danger. Only about 1% opted to pay for the album, resulting in earnings below the band's expectations. But the authors also discuss musician Jane Siberry, who saw significant earnings from her "pay as you wish" online music store as a result of many listeners choosing to pay more than the store's suggested prices. Hence, the "pay as you wish" model may _____ blank

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. prove financially successful for some musicians but disappointing for others.
- B. hold greater financial appeal for bands than for individual musicians.
- C. cause most musicians who use the model to lower the suggested prices of their songs and albums over time.
- D. more strongly reflect differences in certain musicians' popularity than traditional pricing models do.

In the South Pacific, New Caledonian crows use two different kinds of stick tools. One tool is complex. The crows shape a stick from a rare plant into a hook. The other tool is basic. The crows find a stick without a hook on the ground. The hooked tool is harder to get but is much better than the basic tool at removing prey from holes. When studying New Caledonian crows, ecologist Barbara Klump found that they hold the hooked tools in their claws when not using them, or they carefully put them in a safe place. The crows don't do the same with the basic tools. This suggests to Klump that the _____ blank

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. hooked stick tools are more valuable to the crows than the stick tools without hooks.
- B. hooked stick tools are easier for most of the crows to hold than the stick tools without hooks.
- C. crows prefer to share their hooked stick tools but don't share the stick tools without hooks.
- D. crows realize that both kinds of stick tools are less effective than their claws are at removing prey from holes.

Researchers wanted to study how consumers' reactions to an ad may be affected by other ads. The researchers began by showing study participants an ad for a product, with some seeing a less detailed ad and others seeing a more detailed one. Then, all participants viewed the same second ad for a store and shared their opinion of the store based on this second ad. Participants who had first seen an ad less detailed than the second ad had a higher opinion of the store than the participants who had first seen a more detailed ad. The researchers concluded that reactions to an ad may be affected by _____ blank

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. the number of people who viewed the ad.
- B. the length of time viewing previous ads.
- C. the amount of detail viewed in previous ads.
- D. the time of day that the ad is viewed.

One aspect of in-person shopping that online shopping can't replicate is the opportunity to touch a product before buying it. Does this difference matter? In an experiment, researchers asked one group of participants to touch a mug and a toy, while another group was prohibited from touching the two items. The participants were then asked how much money they'd pay for the items. People who got to touch the items were willing to pay much more money for them than were people who weren't allowed to touch the items. This finding suggests that _____ blank

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. people who mainly shop online probably spend more money every month than people who mainly shop in person do.
- B. in-person shopping may make products seem more valuable than they seem if only viewed online.
- C. retailers with in-person and online stores should charge the same price for a given product in both places.
- D. online retailers may be able to raise the prices they charge for products that are only available online.

Researchers Eugeni Vidal-Tortosa and Robin Lovelace looked at the relationship between street lighting in a city and people's willingness to ride a bicycle. Their results suggest that poor street lighting can deter new or inexperienced cyclists from riding in a city but has little effect on experienced cyclists. Therefore, increasing the number of streetlights in a city could potentially _____ blank

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. decrease the number of new or inexperienced cyclists riding in the city.
- B. increase the number of experienced cyclists riding in the city.
- C. decrease the number of experienced cyclists riding in the city.
- D. increase the number of new or inexperienced cyclists riding in the city.